floppy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/44524579.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

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by n7punk

Summary

Catra has a stressful day when things go wrong at the Fright Zone revitalization project, and instead of finding comfort when she comes home, she finds her girlfriend *floppy*. She panics until she finds out that a First Ones infection didn't cause it this time – then her stomach just twists in knots instead.
(Or, Shadow Weaver drank wine, and the consequences that has)

Notes

CONTENT WARNING: alcohol consumption, implied/referenced child abuse (it's Shadow Weaver), and the past mixing of those two. Basically the triggers you can assume from the summary. I'm going with the vague idea that Etheria's drinking age is 18. The group is allowed in bars seemingly without any issues, which is about my only evidence/reasoning. Shadow Weaver's tendencies with alcohol come from the scene where she's drunk in season five and that one art NDDid on livestream of "wine mom" Shadow Weaver back when Catra and Adora were kids.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra was supposed to be back home hours ago, but right when they were about to wrap up construction for the day, the Fright Zone decided it would jump over their planned schedule and put a building they weren't going to take apart for weeks at the head of the line. Catra had just reached the edge of the kingdom-turned-construction zone when she heard groaning in the distance followed by the crashing of a collapse.

A lot of the buildings got damaged during the occupation, but this damage came from before that – from her , and Hordak, weakening the structure when his cannon fired through it. The whole building didn't collapse or anything – they've done assessment risks, because Catra might not have any experience in construction before this, but there are people on the team who do and she's not fucking around or taking risks while reclaiming this place and turning it into something *good* – but everything in the Fright Zone is built on top of something else and one of those upper construction layers was in worse shape than the others. The floors above it just collapsed in on themselves.

No one was over there. It was fine. They have to throw out their entire schedule, not to mention spend tomorrow reassessing *everything* to make sure there are no other disasters imminent, but even when Catra wants to have a breakdown – and given they're in the Fright Zone, it's probably 50/50 on if it would be a crying or violent fit, at least if it weren't for Scorpia's presence helping to remind her to breathe – she manages to hold it together while they make sure no one was hurt and figure out their new plan.

It's the most stressful day of the Fright Zone reclamation project they've had since the very first, and the first was mostly because Catra had no idea what she was doing or how people would react to her. If it would help, Catra would stay even later trying to figure how far off track they have strayed. She works as much as she can, but she doesn't know shit about assessing buildings. Working later would mean forcing other people to stay too, and while she would have done that to her subordinates back when she was Hordak's

Second without hesitating, they arent in *problem* mode anymore.

It doesnt matter how badly she wants everything repaired, the vision of fixing something that has been broken since long before she came around intoxicating in the possibilities it offers to heal and be *healed*. If she wants to actually be better, then everyone needs time to sleep and relax—herself included, even if she might be tempted otherwise when it comes to problems that she could fix herself. They all stay late given the circumstances, but eventually Catra has to make the call for them to stop for the day.

"You did good today, Wildcat," Scorpia assures her before she leaves—before she can *stop* herself leave, because once they are alone she turns to Scorpia and faceplants into her back so she can just hide in darkness for a minute. Scorpia reaches back and awkwardly tries to pat her, which doesnt work great with her pincers even when theyre in a good position, but Catra takes it as the reassurance she needs. She draws in a deep breath and blows it out, trusting Scorpia to *not* see her in this moment—there's a reason she's behind her, okay, and it has everything to do with her fear of vulnerability—as she recenters herself.

"Thanks, Scorpia," she manages. Her voice sounds genuine despite how she's hiding. She can *feel* Scorpia perking up despite her having just gone through the exact same stress. She should be as exhausted as Catra is. Then again, everyone—Scorpia included—kind of defaults to Catra when it comes to shit like this. Sometimes it makes her feel good about how she's doing that theyre willing to turn to her for leadership, and other times she wishes she knew how to take the weight off her shoulder for good.

She cant. She needs some weight to hold her down. She and Adora are the same way like that—really, she thinks all her friends are. Scorpia never seems weighted, but she's just better at shouldering it than most and she is usually in the position to defer to someone else if she doesnt know what to do. Until now, Catra has never been in a position where it is safe to admit that she doesnt know how to

handle something, or for her to screw up if she wrongly thinks that she can. The stakes of a *killing* are pretty bad, but she isn't the final word here – it's *Hordy* Scorpia's kingdom, even if Scorpia is still getting out of the subordinate mindset and Catra is struggling to let go of responsibility – and no one is going to put her to death for failing.

Growing up with that possibility kind of makes it hard to relax. Scorpia doesn't push her though, centering her with her mere presence and a steady – if clumsy – touch. Scorpia always *did* before, but she also loved when Catra would open up to her and would sometimes manage not to ruin it for both of them. Ugh. Okay, so that's what Catra would have said during the war. Scorpia actually did help. Sometimes she did make it worse, and sometimes Catra just *had* her to have made it worse, but she tried to sacrifice herself before Scorpia could get dragged down with her for a *plan*, even if it didn't work thanks to Entrapta… *or* her sentence.

Catra always cared about her despite her best efforts. She's glad to have her now, even if she does have Melog. She needed them both to get through today without snapping at someone. Well, she did yell, but it was barking orders back when they were trying to assess if anyone had been hurt or trapped, so that's fine. Even Melog agrees in the back of her mind. She's glad for them both. She's glad to be in a place where she can destress with Scorpia for a moment before she finally heads home.

"I'm here any time you need, Wildcat," Scorpia promises her, voice soft, as Catra pulls away. Catra flicks an ear, and if Scorpia were Adora – or if she could even *see* her – that would be acknowledgement enough, but Catra feels bad walking away without saying anything more and Melog is nudging her in the back of her mind, even if they're already standing by the door, ready to go. They're almost as tired as Catra is after running around the debris with her and trying to keep her level. She's so lucky Melog doesn't need as much rest as she does.

"You kept me sane today," is what Catra comes out with as she walks towards the door, an acknowledgement of how much Scorpia helps her without having to outright say something gross like *you're the one* at the end of such a stressful day. Melog nudges their head into her hand as she reaches them, a move they claim is affectionate despite their obvious ulterior motives of getting some pets. She lets Melog play whatever games they want, though, because they warn her when Scorpia lights up and starts walking up behind her back.

"Okay, I have to hug you for that," she declares, which Catra was already expecting after Melog warned her of Scorpia's approach. She groans, but she goes limp as Scorpia picks her up. It's easier than fighting it. Scorpia's hugs aren't all that bad. Catra may be desperately looking forward to when she can get home and collapse face forward into Adora's arms, but these arms are pretty good too.

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Her recharge moment with Scorpia gave her the bandwidth to get back home, but that's about it. It's after dinner time and long past when she normally gets back, but she did send a message to the castle that there had been a setback and she wouldn't be home until late. She doesn't know if Adora was worried – anxiety tends to be Adora's thing – or if she has just been waiting around all evening. Either way, she doesn't know if Adora has eaten dinner without her or if she has something she needs to do tonight, so her evening is still up in the air and she just wants some certainty and quiet at this point.

First she has to find Adora, but it isn't that hard thanks to how loud she is. When Catra goes to check their room, she hears laughing coming from Glimmer's room all the way down the hall. It's both a relief and an annoyance. She isn't in the mood for whatever

party of two – well, probably three – Glimmer seems to be throwing right now, but she's glad Adora is close and she doesn't have to go searching for her.

She knocks and gets a loud – and slurred, how hard is Glimmer laughing that it changes how her voice sounds? – call of "Come in!" that has Catra pinning her ears back, but she reluctantly pushes the door open and looks inside. She was right about the group in the room, Adora drooping off the window seat and Bow sat up properly on it with Glimmer tucked into his arms. Honestly, she's drooping as much as Adora is, Bow is just holding her up. There's something in the air that immediately sets Catra's teeth on edge despite the smile Glimmer is sporting and the lazy grin on Adora's face as she lolls her head over and spots Catra. Her eyes go wide, but the movement – all her movements – are weirdly slow as she lifts her arms and makes grabby hands in Catra's direction.

"Catra!" she calls, slurred, happy and not at all how she usually sounds. Catra freezes in place, her heartrate skyrocketing. No. No, it's not possible. Scorpia broke it. The disk shouldn't be able to infect Adora anymore. Did they miss something? Was there another one somewhere? Adora was supposed to be at the castle all day today, but maybe somebody found it and brought it in without knowing what it was. Glimmer and Bow are relaxed, so they seem to just find Adora's antics funny, but Catra is on the precipice of that full-scale meltdown she avoided earlier.

"Adora, what happened?" she demands as she runs forward, Melog hot on her heels. Adora squints up at her, seemingly confused, as Catra reaches her and kneels, hands reaching for her shoulders immediately and running down her arms as if she'll find the disk hidden up her sleeve.

"I was waiting for you," Adora replies, the vowels turning into a slurring sound for a long moment before Adora manages to remember the rest of her sentence. It's a more coherent response than Adora usually gave while "floppy," at least from what Catra has heard, but it doesn't come close to answering her question.

"Catra, she' s not hurt," Bow says, somewhere off to the side. It doesnt calm Catra' s heartrate. Despite how Catra is checking her over for injuries, she knows Adora isnt hurt – she trusts Glimmer and Bow enough to not be smiling and laughing if there were the case – but Adora' s floppy again and that shouldnt be possible, so how are they going to fix

That shouldnt be possible.

"Catra? Are you okay?" Adora asks, her gaze a bit cloudy, but what is there is wholly focused on Catra. Adora raises her hands and cups Catra's cheek. She's not in great control of herself and does it with force somewhere between a romantic caress and a full slap, but the touch still makes Catra feel a little better. She takes a deep breath.

"What happened?" she manages to ask in a calmer voice. Adora' s frown deepens, but Catra can see her gears turning, even if she's clearly a few steps behind.

"Adora' s just drunk. Shell be fine once she sleeps it off," Bow says, off to the side. Catra's heart drops and she recoils a little, her ears pinning back. Adora gasps as Glimmer, seriously missing the mood of the room, giggles.

"She-ra' s a light-weight," she singsongs. Catra immediately scowls, but before she can snap at her, Adora draws Catra's attention back to her. Adora frames Catra's face with both of her hands and nearly falls over in the process. Melog sees her wavering the moment she stops supporting herself with her arm, though, and they rush in to push her upright with their head before she can fall. Adora barely seems to notice, locking eyes with Catra. Her expression is wide-eyed and anxious, all the strange *floppi*ness suddenly gone – or at least pushed down.

"Glimmer gave me wine and it hit me harder than I thought. Im okay. Just warm and fuzzy. It' s not the poison Shadow Weaver made it out to be," Adora promises her, voice serious despite how her words are still running together a little. Catra winces, but she doesnt pull back

again. *Drunk* is a word she knows, a stupid, vulnerable state people get to with alcohol, and she's more than aware of the drink that Shadow Weaver would indulge in on occasion, but those *ones* have built strong associations of things like that for her, and she hates seeing Adora like this.

Catra sniffs the air and now, with Adora's breath so close and knowing what to look for in the air, she can pick up the smell. It isn't exactly as she remembers, but the burn that all the alcohol she has crossed has is definitely there along with a similar pungent scent to what Shadow Weaver's drink of choice had. Neither of them knew much about alcohol before they got separated by the war – Shadow Weaver told them wine was poisonous to humans and magicats the first time they found her drinking it – but Catra learned enough about it while occupying the Crimson Waste to know that while Shadow Weaver wasn't wrong, elves aren't any more immune to its effects either.

Catra reaches a hand up to cover Adora's own and gently turns her head away from Adora's touch, replacing it with their interlaced fingers so she is free to cast her gaze around the room. The wine bottle, once again reminiscent of her childhood memories but not identical, is sat on the window sill, two of the glasses that are *by* as she remembers them set beside it. Catra's breathing is going a little too fast looking at them.

She knows for some of Etheria, this is just a dumb thing they do for fun without any thought of consequences. It isn't for Catra. All she can do is remember consequences. Shadow Weaver wasn't, actually, much worse when she drank. That would be a pretty high bar to reach, so her actions tended to fall on the below-average side – in retrospect, she probably wasn't physically able to do all that much while drunk – but her tongue sharpened and her mood grew more erratic. She was always meaner *after*, too, seemingly to punish them for bothering her while she was taking time to herself.

"Catra," Adora says, voice low and serious as she tries to reach up for her face again. Catra flinches and Adora freezes. For a long

moment, Catra can't meet her eyes. The other thing that changed about Shadow Weaver when she was drunk is that she tended to touch more. A hand on the top of their heads, weirdly soothing and terrifying, or a sharp slap at Catra's hand when she reached for the drink to correct it nearly tipping out of her hand. Face touches were something Shadow Weaver did way too much. Almost no one but Shadow Weaver or Adora would touch Catra's face, and in this moment, something she normally melts into when Adora gives it is sending a shiver down her spine.

"It's okay. I'm okay. I'm sorry, I forgot you probably haven't learned much more about this stuff yet," Adora rallies when Catra still doesn't look at her. Catra feels the room still as the jovial attitude coming from Glimmer finally catches up with the situation. Catra closes her eyes and takes a few breaths, and then quickly opens them when that just makes her more aware of the scent on the air.

"No, I have. I spent time in the Crimson Waste, remember? Kind of a lot of alcohol there," Catra manages to roll her eyes, but when she glances back to Adora's face, she doesn't look reassured. Catra gives up on trying to lighten things. She sighs, standing and bending to reach for Adora. Adora reaches back, and with Melog helping to nudge her up, Catra manages to pull Adora up onto her feet. Adora makes a quiet *hm* sound and sways a little in place, but Catra locks her arms around her and holds her up.

"I just don't like seeing you like this," Catra whispers, looking over Adora's shoulder at the wine. *I'd rather you be like me*, she doesn't say, because no matter what Adora could *never* be like her. She wonders if Adora can tell how close she comes to thinking it, though. On a good day, Adora might. While drunk, there's no telling. Catra has never touched a drink herself – the very idea terrifies her for multiple reasons – but she knows that mostly it clouds the head, weakens decision making, and lowers inhibitions. And makes everything warm and fuzzy, apparently.

Adora isn't going to act like anything other than *floppy* which, while a pain to deal with in a prisoner, is probably fine. When Glimmer told

the story of their first run-in with the disk, she seemed to find it funny in retrospect. Maybe if this hadn't been sprung on Catra – and it wasn't at the end of a bad day – she would be able to handle it. Right now, she just wants it to stop. She wants Adora back to normal and she wants the scent of wine gone.

"I drink a lot of water I'll sober up quicker," Adora offers, her voice somewhere between hopeful and triumphant. The thought seems to have just occurred to her. Catra takes a deep breath, nodding and meeting her eyes.

"Let's get you water," she says. Adora nods, lurching a little in her arms with the movement and quickly stopping to squint her eyes closed as she regains her balance. They can't start walking until she is steady – well, as steady as she is going to get like this – again, so Catra glances to the side to make eye contact with Bow. If he has been drinking at all, he has had the least. He's acting *normal* at least, and he seems concerned watching Catra and Adora without looking unduly wide-eyed and maybe even teary like Glimmer does.

"Make sure she doesn't drink too much water either or it could make her sick. Food helps soak up the alcohol too. I've got to keep babysitting Glimmer, but they'll both be fine in a few hours," Bow tells her, voice steady and serious. Catra is grateful for the directions, nodding as Adora's eyes open and Catra risks shifting her hands to wrap an arm around her waist so she can hold Adora steady for the walk. Catra points to Glimmer, who blinks at her in surprise.

"You're on my shit list for the next week," Catra informs her, remembering Adora's phrasing of *light*. Glimmer's mouth falls open and she looks offended, but Catra doesn't wait for her to finish her indignant sound before she points to Bow. "Thank you for watching them," she tells him. Bow nods to her as Glimmer makes some more indistinct noises of protest and reaches in their general direction, but Bow is still bundling her in his arms and Catra is already turning away to walk Adora out. Melog circles them carefully, ready to catch Adora if she falls.

"She was having fun until you came in!" Glimmer calls at their backs, immediately shushed by Bow. A shiver runs through Catra as they walk away. Her heartrate still hasn't returned to normal. She doesn't know that it's going to until morning.

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Adora has already eaten dinner, apparently, but she was planning to eat a second one with Catra when she got back anyway, so Melog goes to pester the kitchen staff for food because that's what Bow said to do, and Adora vaguely echoes the same idea when she determines that she has to sober up with the usual focus she applies to things, only this time considerably easier to distract – and less coordinated – than usual.

"I didn't mean to get so drunk. I just kind of lost track while I was waiting for you," Adora says. Her voice has had a pleading quality to it every time she has tried to explain away her own inebriation despite Catra's answer being the same every time: it's okay, just drink more water. Bow also said not to let her get sick on it, though, so when Adora tries to explain this time Catra reaches for the glass loosely rested in her hand and takes it away with a sigh, setting it on the bedside table. She brought Adora to the bed because her balance is *still* right now and Catra doesn't trust her anywhere else.

"I didn't want to be so late. It was a really big setback we were trying to work around," she says. Her mind immediately wants to twist it and say *you're the setback if you're late*, but right now she's almost too focused on making sure Adora is okay to hate herself. *Bow*, anyway. When they're trying to fall asleep it's going to be another story. Adora frowns deeply. Catra ignores it, reaching for her shoulders and nudging Adora a little closer to the center of the bed.

"Tell me about it," Adora requests. Catra pauses, glancing up to make eye contact. It's the first thing Adora has said that isn't immediately related to her drunkenness. Then again, Catra hasn't said *anything* that isn't. Nothing is going to distract her from it, really, but Melog won't be back for awhile and she has to do something other than be worried and uncomfortable until then. She sighs and shifts up the bed to flop down beside Adora on her back. Adora immediately makes an excited sound, at odds with how serious she has been trying to act ever since she realized Catra was upset, and wiggles to get better positioned next to her.

Catra launches into an explanation of the collapse and the rush of last-minute planning that followed the "rescue" efforts. Adora makes little noises as she speaks, but Catra isn't sure how well she is listening considering she starts rubbing her face on Catra's shoulder halfway through. Catra isn't sure why – she doesn't *know* – Adora isn't so drunk that she has forgotten she isn't a magicat – but it's affectionate and kind of at odds with the story she is telling. Adora's being sweet, though, and she's probably at least *trying* to listen, so it helps with Catra's anxiety some.

When Catra finishes her explanation, silence hangs in the air for several long seconds. Adora stops rubbing her face on her after a moment, but she leaves it tucked against Catra's shoulder.

"I'm sorry. I shouldn't be stressing you more right now by being drunk, but I was selfish and didn't think about that," Adora murmurs. Catra gazes up at the ceiling, a frown settling into her features slowly.

"Selfish?" she asks, because Adora feels that in a lot of places it doesn't apply, but she isn't quite sure how it *can* apply here even with Adora logic. Feeling guilty for being drunk when it stresses Catra – whether she knew it would or not – makes sense, at least for Adora, but it wasn't selfish of her to drink what Glimmer gave her in the first place.

"I wasn't thinking about how you'd feel when you got home. When Glimmer decided she wanted to have wine tonight, I said yes because I wanted to prove to myself that I didn't have to be..." she trails off, seemingly searching for a word, "vigilant, anymore. Or something. I just... wanted to prove it was safe to be vulnerable. I couldn't leave Etheria without She-ra, before," Adora rambles, her words quiet and far from organized, but at least they aren't slurring into each other all that much anymore. Maybe the water is helping.

Catra takes a deep breath. She knows that vigilance as well as Adora does. The context differs – the weight on her shoulders was usually her own life, not the entire planet that she had placed there in her drive for sacrifice – but the fear of vulnerability is deeply engrained in her bones. Catra reaches over, awkwardly twisting her torso so she can throw an arm over Adora without turning her face towards her alcohol breath. Adora makes a small, happy sound and curls into her.

"Okay . That's not a bad thing to want. It just scared me to come home and see you like this. I thought you had been *hit* again," Catra says. Adora lets out a small gasp, which Catra can admit is kind of cute. It's horrified, but definitely more horrified than is justified by her words. Catra doesn't like much about this situation, but she thinks that if she were prepared for it, and it was a good day, and they had *not* been about alcohol in general, she might find drunk Adora kind of funny. Maybe.

She never was going to today.

"No! I just had too much. I won't do it again," Adora promises. Catra doesn't reply to that. She probably should say something like *you don't have to promise that*, but she wouldn't mean it if she did. She understands why Adora decided to do it, but she wishes she would have proven it some other way. This is the first time that something healing for one of them has been outright damaging to the other, but hopefully Adora only needed this once.

"It'll be okay," Catra promises. It's more of a vague hope than anything else. Sober, Adora would call her out in a heartbeat, but drunk Adora lets out a small sigh and rubs her face into her shoulder again.

Yeah, Catra wants her Adora back.

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The water was helping slowly, and the food really makes a difference. Adora is still a bit off, and she confesses that her thoughts feel especially slow, but she stops slurring and she regains her balance by the time they finish eating. She then asks if she can brush Catra's hair, which Catra is pretty sure is a request fueled by guilt, but Adora enjoys doing it and Catra maybe more than tolerates it, so she allows it. It doesn't hurt like it used to when she had long hair and the Horde's sad excuse for hair products left it constantly tangled. She still likes it unbrushed and messy, but having Adora's hands running through her hair is nice, and there's definitely some debris and dust that needs to be brushed out tonight.

Catra lays on the bed with her head in Adora's lap as Adora carefully works on brushing through her hair – it's only soothing if Adora *does* it, which can be a challenge even with Catra's hair this short – and Melog curls around them both. *I'm glad I'm here for you* is the sentiment they send Catra, which honestly makes her smile as Adora carefully folds her ear out of the way to brush at its base. She's feeling a little better now Adora is talking normally again. For awhile, the silence is okay, but that thought she worried would haunt her slowly begins to loom again now that her worry has been abated.

"Glimmer said you were having fun," Catra finally says, an innocent enough statement. Her eyes are closed so she doesn't see how

Adora reacts to that, but the brush pauses for a long moment before Adora resumes brushing.

"Yeah. Im a giggly drunk, apparently . It makes everything funnier ," she says. Okay, so Glimmer was right, Catra did ruin it. And now Adora has spent the last hour promising Catra it will never happen again because she could tell it nearly caused Catra to have a breakdown. She realizes she' s frowning when Adora sets the brush aside and frames her head with her hands.

"I know you probably still only associate drinking with Shadow Weaver. It' s a lot more normal here. Glimmer wasnt old enough to do it when Ifirst joined up and they werent going to offer it to me when Ididnt really know my exact age, but Ive been around it at celebrations and stuff for awhile now. Im more used to it,"Adora says, her voice soft as she explains. Catra' s ears twitch back, but she doesnt say anything, letting Adora explain. She didnt know there was an exact *Hogwarts* on when you could have the stuff, but she has heard comments about it being for adults, so it's not shocking or anything. More funny to think about a commander in the Rebellion not being old enough to drink yet.

"Bow and Icould have had it, but Inever really considered it an option and he never brought up wanting to do it, so the closest Iever came was when Sea Hawk tried to hand me a mug once. It just didnt feel like a safe thing to do. Even when Istopped associating it with her , Icouldnt risk being unfit to fight. After Glimmer said how I acted while infected was like Iwas drunk, Iwas even less interested,"Adora continues, petting Catra' s ears. Catra nods reluctantly. All of that makes sense to her, and Adora kind of said it earlier, but she was drunker then so some context was mssing.

"It is fun, kind of. It doesnt feel anything like Ithought it would when we were younger, anyway. Everything gets kind of rosy and things stop feeling like they matter so much. Like there's less anxiety . Ithink that' s why Iended up drinking so much when Iwas waiting for you. Istarted, and it felt good, and then it got hard to track how much Id had,"Adora continues. Catra winces. She doesnt know if it' s just

the description or the fact it directly relates Adora's state back to her, but she doesnt like it. Adora settles her hands on either side of Catra's head again, holding her. Catra doesnt know what it is about being drunk that makes Adora want to touch her head so much.

"And then you were worried and it suddenly wasnt fun anymore. I realized Icouldnt think clearly and Im not- Im still not sober enough to be there for you or to explain it and Ihate this. Idont like not being in control. Ijust want to be okay again so we can be okay again,"Adora continues, words quieting to a mumble. Catra opens her eyes, gazing up to find Adora's head is hung, but she cant exactly hide when Catra is looking up at her from her lap. Catra reaches up and covers one of Adora's hands with her own, maintaining eye contact as she turns her head to nuzzle into Adora's touch.

"We're okay. You worried me, but we're okay,"Catra promises, and this time she means it. She's still a little fuzzy on what Adora was getting out of it, but this far into the night, she does know they're going to be fine. Adora blows out a breath and offers her a grateful smile. Catra turns her head a bit more to press a kiss to the palm of her hand and then lets her head roll back into a neutral position. After a moment, Adora strokes her fingers through her hair and then picks back up the brush.

"Just dont make it a habit or get drunk without warning me. If you want to do it again, Iwant to be there with you,"Catra tells her. Adora nods, her expression serious, as she resumes brushing through Catra's hair.

"It's not something Id want to do much anyway. Everything being funnier is nice, Iguess, but not being able to react to things doesnt feel good even when Idont have a war to worry about,"Adora promises her. Catra gives the tiniest nod, aborting the movement as soon as she feels the slight tug of the brush. That's enough for her. Adora said she has been around it more since coming to Bright Moon, so maybe with time Catra will get used to it too and it wont be so tied to hateful words and impending punishments mixed with

weirdly sweet moments that just make the whole thing worse, but right now she isn't comfortable with it. She counts herself lucky that this is one hang up of hers that Adora seems to understand perfectly. She wouldn't be explaining it this much if she didn't know that Catra needed her to.

The brush pulls a little too hard and Catra winces. Immediately, Adora reaches with both hands and holds her hair at the base so she can brush it without tugging on Catra's scalp. Catra tries to take a deep breath and think beyond just what this whole thing makes her feel. Adora is so considerate and Catra has been struggling to be the same tonight. She thinks that's justified given [illegible], but she does her best to be a good girlfriend to Adora – and a good person, by extension – so she really should try to focus on Adora's angle for a moment.

Adora seems to understand Catra's reservations and is willing to work with them, which is kind of the bare minimum of understanding they need to reach for this in general and definitely good enough for while Adora is still sobering up. Adora implied that Glimmer offered her the wine and she decided she was ready for it on her own, so Catra isn't really mad at Glimmer anymore. Her mental checklist pauses on that thought, though. She looks up to make eye contact with Adora again. It takes Adora a minute to realize, focused on getting Catra's hair to the point where she can just brush through it and it's relaxing, but she holds Catra's eyes once she catches her gaze.

"I'm glad you felt comfortable enough to try it," Catra says, like an adult. She is proud, at least now that she can think that beyond her own concerns to realize how hard that was for Adora. She still wishes this wasn't something Adora tied safety to – needing it, or being afraid of it – but laying her burdens down is like, at least half of Adora's problem. Adora sends her a small smile before she returns to the tangled section of her hair.

"Yeah. It was okay. Not as freeing as I wanted, and I definitely won't be doing it again for a while, but I'm glad I felt like that too, even

though I'm sorry now ," Adora decides, which is leaps and bounds of progress, actually. Catra's pretty sure Adora's old normal would have had her too consumed by guilt to feel anything positive about any step of a process that worried someone else by now. Catra reaches up to capture her hand, bringing it to her mouth to kiss it and not at all benefiting from how it stops Adora from brushing her hair for a moment.

I'm proud of you," she says more plainly , because Adora says it whenever Catra makes progress, no matter how incremental, and Catra wants to do the same for her. Catra would blame the lingering alcohol for how close Adora's sparkling eyes come close to tearing up, but Adora might respond like this to praise on any rough day. It's beautiful, though, to see her so touched.

"Thank you," Adora whispers, her voice quiet but loaded. Her reactions to Catra tonight have been as opposite as they could possibly be to how Shadow Weaver acted while drunk. It wasn't the alcohol making her like that, it was all just her . Catra still ties the drink closely with her, but with time that connection might fade. It's still not something she's interested in for herself, and she still doesn't love the idea of Adora behaving differently either, but giggly Adora might be fun if she isn't so gone.

Catra can get to the point where alcohol doesn't make her anxious, she's sure now, and that means it will all be okay eventually. Maybe she'll even get to a point where she can just find drunk Glimmer funny, because she did seem as equally loopy as Adora. It isn't today, and it isn't going to be soon even, but given how tonight has gone and what Adora has told her, she has hope.

This is far from how she thought her evening would go, but she's in Adora's arms and as hard as it feels, they're communicating and she's feeling better because of it. Things aren't just going to be okay —they're okay right now .

End Notes

Adora is not, actually, a lightweight (girl's metabolism is crazy to put away the food that she does and she's a First One, plus there's She-ra), Glimmer just had no idea how much Adora had actually drank because she wasnt sober enough to be tracking that lol

This fic was loosely (and pre-emptively) referenced in chardonnay. Ididnt write it then because Ididnt want to mess around with triggers, but for some reason it occurred to me again the other day and Iactually sat down to work on it.

Explanation of the Fright Zone construction, if youre curious. I tried to make it make sense on its own here without rehashing too much since it's referenced in so many of my post-canon fics.

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